

SELF-IDENTIFICATION DETERMINED THROUGH STAGES OF CONSCIOUSNESS

Greetings and blessings are poured forth unto all of you here, in a great and magnificent spiritual force which you can partake of and assimilate to whatever degree you truly open yourself to it -- with your heart and your mind.

In tonight's lecture I will discuss consciousness again, from a new and different approach; for many of my friends involved in this work have become ready to make use of this particular lecture and, in fact, very badly need it in order to consolidate the material gained on their path so far. This concerns primarily the problem of self-identification, which we have of course discussed in the past but into which we can now go more deeply and profoundly and comprehensively with the progress that has been gained since then.

It is perhaps difficult for human beings to understand that consciousness permeates the entire universe and creation. It is not simply dependent on and existing through personality or the personification of an entity. It permeates everything that exists. The human mind is geared to think that consciousness is exclusively a by-product of personality, that it can exist only in the human form. It is even associated with the brain as the exclusive manifestation of consciousness. This is not so. Consciousness does not require a fixed form. Every particle of matter contains consciousness. But in inanimate matter, consciousness is petrified, just as energy is petrified in inanimate objects. Consciousness and energy are not the same, but they are interdependent aspects of the manifestation of life.

As the ascent of evolution progresses, this petrification lessens and consciousness and energy become increasingly more vibrant and moving. Consciousness gains increasing awareness; energy has increasingly greater creative power to move, build, make form.

Consciousness has experienced, through processes impossible to convey to the human understanding, a separation so that aspects of consciousness "float around" in the universe, if I may use this expression. Every trait familiar to human understanding, every attitude known in creation, every aspect of personality is one of many manifestations of consciousness. Every one of them that is not yet integrated into the whole needs to be unified, synthesized, made part of the harmonious whole. It requires a leap of your imagination to comprehend the concept I am trying to convey here. Can you imagine for a moment that many traits familiar to you, which you have always associated with the person as existing only through a person, are not the person per se, but are free-floating particles of the overall consciousness, whether these be good or evil traits or apparently indifferent ones? (In reality there are no indifferent traits.) Take love or perseverance or sloth or laziness (about which I shall give a lecture in itself some time in the future, for it is more important than meets the eye) or impatience or kindness or stubbornness or malice. It matters not what it is, they all need to be incorporated into the manifesting personality. Only then does purification,

harmonization, and enrichment of the manifesting consciousness take place, which create the evolutionary process of unifying the separated particles of consciousness.

It is important to note that the disharmonious, destructive aspects of consciousness always remain separate. They cannot be unified and integrated. This needs no leap of the imagination. It can be readily verified by each individual who observes this process in himself. The positive traits, the constructive aspects of consciousness, are always a harmonious part of the whole, thus enriching every other trait and expanding the consciousness as a whole. I cannot convey in the slightest the full reality of these ideas because the human language is much too limited. But I do not intend to give you an abstract lecture of which you can make no use. I will come, in a minute, to very personal and practical applications of this new approach.

Each aspect of consciousness has, according to its nature, its own characteristics, its own vibratory movement and frequency rate in energy movement, its own emanation, its own color and scent, its own tone, and many other sense expressions of which the human state of development knows nothing. The senses that exist in reality exceed by far the known spectrum of senses as perceived by human beings. There are infinitely more colors, tones, scents, etc.

The human being is a conglomeration of aspects of consciousness. Some are already purified, some have always been pure and are thus part of the individuality, no longer separate and therefore disharmonious. They form an integrated whole. Other aspects are negative, destructive and are thus separate. They may be likened to appendices. It is the task of each human being in each incarnation to synthesize, unify, and assimilate various such aspects of consciousness. If you truly try to comprehend what I say here you may find that this is a novel way of explaining human existence. Naturally this does not only apply to the level of human consciousness, but also to higher developed states of consciousness. Only then, the struggle is no longer as severe or as painful. The increased awareness of the higher states facilitates the synthesizing process immeasurably. The human predicament is the nonunderstanding of what is going on, the blindness with which the individual is involved in the struggle, and his deliberate attempt to perpetuate this blindness.

To the degree there exists struggle and tension in a "personification," to that degree the various aspects of consciousness are at odds with one another. The entity is unaware of the meaning of the struggle and is trying to identify with one or several of these aspects without knowing which or what is the true self. Where is it located? What is it? How can it be found in the maze of this discord? Are you your best? Are you your over-severe conscience that annihilates you for your negative traits? Or are you the destructive demon? Is your rage at the demon in you, or is the total negation of its existence your best self? Surely this attitude seems the most moral and conscientious. Whether individuals know it or not, there is this ongoing inner struggle and search. The more conscious the struggle is, the better, of course. We must now try to find answers to these questions by giving full attention to this problem. Any path of self-development must sooner or later come to terms with these questions -- with the deep problem of self-identity.

It is a human distortion to identify with any of the above-mentioned aspects. You are neither the negative traits nor your self-punishing conscience nor even your positive traits. But you have managed to integrate the latter into the fullness of your being. However, this is not the same as making them you. It is more accurate to say that that which managed this is you, that which integrated and determined, decided and acted, thought and willed, is you and could thus absorb what

was previously an appendix with its own contradictory directions and expressions. Each aspect possesses its own will, as you well know from the pathwork. As long as you are blindly involved in the struggle and therefore submerged in it, the various aspects with their will of their own control you because the self that can determine differently has not yet found its power. This blind involvement enslaves the person and inactivates his creative energy. This leads to despair, due to lack of sense of self. If the personality blindly believes it is its own negativity, its destructive aspects, it becomes encased in a special kind of inner battle. On the one hand, there will be self-annihilation, self-punishment, violent self-hate as a reaction to perceiving the self as only that negative part; on the other hand, how can the personality truly want to give up these traits, to even fully face and investigate them when he believes that this is the only reality of the self? The person is thrown back and forth between, "I must remain as I am, unchanged and unimproved, for this is my only reality and I do not want to cease to exist," and "I am so terrible, so bad, so despicable that I have no right to exist, and I must punish myself out of existence." This conflict is too painful to face when it is believed to be a real issue, so that the entire issue is put aside, as it were, and covered up. One then leads the life of "as if," a pretense, which then shifts the sense of identity and true existence into the pretense. One then struggles against exposing, let alone giving up, the pretense, for the only other alternative is the above-mentioned struggle. No wonder human beings have so much resistance. And yet, what a waste, for none of this is the reality. There is a real self that equals neither the negative aspects, nor the adamant self-annihilation, nor the pretense that covers it all up. For finding this real self is our concern.

Before the universal self can fully manifest in you, there is already one aspect of it which is available right now, which can be immediately realized. This is your conscious self at its best, as it is now. It is a limited present manifestation of your spiritual being, but it is truly yourself. It is the "I" you need so as to make order in all your confusion. This already manifest consciousness exists in many realms of your life -- and you take it for granted. But you have not yet brought it to bear on the area of this conflict where you continue to be blindly controlled by the false self-identity, or rather its consequences.

The "I" that is able to make a decision, for instance, to truly face this conflict, to observe its various expressions -- this is the self with which you may safely identify. To the degree the personality awakens and self-consciousness is gained, such decisions, choices, and determinations are possible. Conversely, to the degree such decisions, choices of attitudes, and determinations are made, the consciousness awakens and expands. This immediately available consciousness of every living human being is usually not fully put to use where his greatest sufferings and conflicts exist. The full scope of its power is not put into the service of the struggle in question. When the entity begins to do this systematically, a major change is taking place. A new stage of development is reached at such a point. To the extent the conscious self uses its already existing knowledge of truth, its already existing power to execute its good will, its already existing capacity to be positive, committed, truthful, courageous, and persevering in the struggle in question, its already existing ability to choose the attitude to the problem, to exactly that degree the consciousness expands and becomes increasingly more infiltrated by the spiritual consciousness. The spiritual consciousness cannot manifest when the already existing consciousness is not fully put to use in the conduct of one's life. Out of using it, new inspiration, new realms of vision and understanding, of profound wisdom and experience well up from the depth of the person. But as long as the line of least resistance is followed and the personality gives in to blind involvement; as long as he gives up on finding a true self-identity and settles blindly for a would-be existence; as long as he follows the rut,

stuck in the old groove of habitual reacting and then explaining this away cheaply; as long as he indulges in compulsive thinking, in negative, hopeless circular thinking, for that long the consciousness of the self -- as it exists now -- is not fully put to use. Consequently consciousness cannot possibly expand and can neither transmute and synthesize the negative aspects it falsely identifies itself with, nor can it bring in deeper aspects of the spiritual self. As long as existing values are not fully put to use, additional values cannot possibly be realized. This is a law of life that applies to all levels of being. This is a very important thing to understand, my friends.

When you identify with one or even a cluster of aspects and believe that these aspects are you, you become submerged in them. At the very beginning, when I started giving lectures, I used the terms "higher self, lower self, and mask self." These are very abbreviated terms, which comprise, of course, many subdivisions and subvariations. As a convenient frame of reference, one may classify certain aspects as belonging to one or the other of these three basic categories.

The genuine will for good is, needless to say, an expression of the higher self. But there is also another will for good, which can easily be confused with the former, though it is by no means the same. It is the will to be good for the sake of appearance, for the sake of denying the lower aspects, because the struggle is not taken up with the conscious, determining, choosing self. The demonical, destructive aspects are obviously an expression of the lower self. But the giant guilt that punishes these destructive aspects with total annihilation is not an expression of the higher self although it may easily pose for it. It is, in fact, more destructive than the destructiveness itself. It comes entirely out of the false self-identification mentioned above. If you believe you are your demon, you seem to have no other choice but to annihilate yourself, yet you dread annihilation and thus hold on to the demon. But if you observe the demon, you can begin to identify with that which observes.

You must never forget that none of you is entirely involved in this struggle. If this were true, there would not yet be a possibility to come out of it. There are many aspects of your being where you use the power of your creative thinking processes, where you expand your mind and thus build productively. But we are now focused on those areas where you are not expanding and productive.

As long as the human entity is unable, or rather unwilling, to recognize his destructive aspects, he must be lost in them. Therefore he can make no proper self-identification. As I said before, this failure to recognize, name, and observe the destructive elements indicates that the self believes it is the destructiveness. Although the desire to hide the destructive aspects is more destructive than whatever it is you hide, at the same time it indicates that you wish to be free from destructiveness. Thus the desire to hide destructiveness is a misplaced, misunderstood, and misread message of the higher self. It is a wrong way of applying and interpreting the longing of the spiritual self. The negation of the destructive aspects, I repeat, leads to an annihilating struggle against self-identity. Now let us discuss further how the conscious self can be more activated and utilized so that you can expand it and make room for the spiritual consciousness to infiltrate it.

Every one of my friends on the path, who have worked diligently and conscientiously to shed the mask, to give up defenses, to overcome the resistance to expose the apparently shameful liabilities have experienced how the acknowledgment of the negative traits creates a new freedom. Why is this so? Of course the obvious answer is the mere fact that you have the courage and honesty to do so is in itself a relieving and liberating factor. But it is more than that, my friends. It goes beyond that. Namely, through the act of acknowledgment, a subtle but distinct shift in

identification occurs. Before such acknowledgment, you were blind to the destructive aspects (or some of them), which indicated that you believed them to be you. Hence you could not afford to acknowledge them because you identified with something unacceptable to you. But the moment you acknowledge the hitherto unacceptable, you cease to be the unacceptable, but you are identified with that in you that is capable of the acknowledgment, that decides to acknowledge! By not acknowledging the aspects you hate in yourself, you are blind to them, hence helplessly controlled by them. By acknowledging them, something else takes over that can do something about them even if that something is, to begin with, merely to observe and to grope for some deeper understanding of the underlying dynamics. It is a totally different situation when you are identified with the ugly traits or when you identify them. The moment you identify them, you cease being identified with them. This is why it is so liberating to acknowledge the worst in the personality after having battled the ever present resistance to do so. This will become even easier when you can make the clear distinction between the aspects you dislike in yourself and your being those aspects.

The moment you identify the destructive aspects, name them, state them, articulate them, observe them, it is that which identifies, names, states, articulates, and observes that is the self with which you can truly and safely and realistically identify. This self holds many options, possibilities, and choices -- the first being what you are doing now: stating, observing, naming, etc. Therefore you no longer need to persecute yourself so mercilessly with your self-hate. There seems to be no way out but hating yourself as long as you have missed out on this all-important process of identifying with that in you that is capable of observing, stating, naming, choosing, determining, adopting new attitudes, facing, dealing with, recognizing, and adjusting without devastating self-judgment. It is possible to judge negatively also in a truthful spirit, but it makes all the difference in the world when you believe what you judge is the only truth of your being, or when you realize that that part that acknowledges the presence of destructiveness has other options and is closer to your ultimate reality.

How different your attitude to yourself must be when you realize that it is the task of human entities to carry negative aspects with them for the purpose of integrating and synthesizing them! This affords truthfulness without hopelessness. What a dignity it lends to you when you consider that you undertake an important task for the sake of evolution. When you come into this life, you bring negative aspects with you for the purpose mentioned. There exist certain meaningful laws which determine what aspects you bring with you, but we cannot go into that now. Every human being fulfills an immense task in the universal scale of evolution. An entity who does not offer, let us say, to fulfill such a task may be quite free, purified, evolved, and harmonious, but it is not contributing to evolution, as any one of you here does. This gives you a great dignity. This dignity is so much more important than the momentary suffering that accrues from not knowing who you are. Do not ever forget that you are not your ugly traits. But there is a difference between total negation of these traits and the awareness I am trying here to convey to you. It is one of those subtle, apparent contradictions that exist so frequently when dealing with the realms that lie beyond duality -- with the realms that are much nearer to ultimate reality. It is necessary to acknowledge the ugly aspects as part of you and take responsibility for them before you can truly understand that you are not these aspects. It is possible to be responsible for them without believing that they are your only reality. Only when you first take responsibility for them can you come to the wonderful realization that you are not them, but you carry something with you for which you have taken responsibility for a certain purpose. Only then can come the next step: integration.

To recapitulate, we have the following steps or stages or states: (1) the half-asleep climate of not knowing who you are and blindly battling against that which you hate in yourself -- consciously, semiconsciously, or unconsciously; (2) the first state of awakening when you can acknowledge, name, articulate, observe that which you do not like; when you feel that this is an aspect of you rather than the secret, ultimate truth about you; (3) the awareness that the "I" is that which observes, confronts, etc. This same "I" can make new dispositions, decisions, and choices. It can look for new, hitherto undreamed of options and possibilities -- not by magic, but by "trying out" attitudes that were totally negated and ignored before. For example, the attitude of setting a positive goal of self-acceptance without losing the sense of proportion; of groping for new ways; of learning from mistakes and failures; of not giving up when immediate success fails to arrive; of putting faith into unknown potentialities which can manifest only as these new modes are adopted by the consciousness; of performing this adoption, which the consciousness is capable of right now. That leads to (4) the eventual comprehension, connection with, and understanding of those previously negated and hated aspects, which means their dissolution and integration. This merger occurs simultaneously with the ever expanding consciousness that takes in more of the spiritual reality, which can now unfold to ever greater degrees. This means purification.

To the extent a life is led in such a way, to that degree consciousness as a whole, as it permeates all, is less split off into its particles and more unified. When you assimilate what I said here, you will understand several all-important facts: first of all, you will see the tremendous overall importance of recognizing the distorted, demonic traits. You will take full responsibility for them which will, paradoxically as this may seem, liberate you from being identified with those aspects. You will know fully that you are you and that these aspects are but appendices or attachments which you can draw into yourself as you dissolve them. That is, their basic energy and undistorted nature can become part of the consciousness that you manifest. This is the first step of true self-identification: that which observes is you, and you are not that which is being observed. Thus, no matter how undesirable it is, it becomes wholly possible to deal with it, to accept it, to explore it, to work with it, to no longer be frightened by it. The capacity to observe and adjudge, to note and evaluate, and, last but not least, to choose the best possible attitudes as to what to do with the observed -- that is the true power of our real self as it already exists right now. Freedom, liberation, the knowledge of self, the finding of self are the first steps toward realizing the greater consciousness, the universal, divine consciousness in you. As long as this is not done, your innermost spiritual consciousness remains only a principle, a theory, and a potentiality to be realized only in the future. You may believe in it with your intellect, but you cannot truly ascertain it in you until you use the consciousness that is already available now, but which you allow to go unused wherever your so-called problems exist. Only as those four stages are gone and worked through, as I outlined them in this lecture, can your conscious mind expand sufficiently to let in the as yet unmanifest wisdom, truth, love, energy, strength of feeling, capacity to transcend painful opposites that will enrich and create your life toward more joy and pleasure.

The moment self-identification takes place, a deep and apparently bottomless terror of the human soul disappears. Often this terror is not consciously experienced. Only on the threshold of these states I described here, during the change from being lost and blind and not knowing what and who you are, to the first inklings of true self-identification, do you become aware of terror. This is a transitional period which may last weeks or many incarnations. You may hide it from yourself or face it. To the degree you do the latter, you come out of it sooner. When you hide it, you have

gained nothing, for the terror will leave its indelible marks in your life, which are not one iota less painful and limiting than the actual experience of the terror, on the contrary.

That terror exists only because you do not know that there is a real you beyond that which you hate. Because of this terror, you so consistently hesitate to identify what you hate. As long as you lack the courage to explore whether your fear is justified or not, you cannot find out that it is not, that you are much, much more than what you fear you are. The human personality is often on the brink of wanting to make this step. But this brink feels like a precipice, which causes the hesitation and the prolonged pseudoexistence. When this point is not dealt with, terror remains in the soul; then the terror is denied and repressed, and this repressed terror has additional adverse effects on the personality, which becomes more and more alienated from its true nucleus.

When you finally make the full decision and commitment toward bridging this gap, the terror disappears and you realize that you can find who you are and that life is full and rich and open and infinite. The moment you experience that you are that which observes and not that which is being observed, there is no longer need to annihilate yourself, to have no other existence but the fraudulent mask or the hateful demon or the petty selfish egotist. So, self-identification removes the terror of annihilation -- not just death, but annihilation. This is different, as you may all sense.

We shall now return once more to the conscious mind as it already exists in you now at this moment. It is now in the state of being able to acknowledge an observation in the self, an aspect of the self. That which observes has many choices, as I said. Your attitude toward your demonic, undeveloped, undesirable traits is the key to expanding your consciousness. You hear so much today about the concept of consciousness expansion. Often this is believed to be a magical process that suddenly occurs. It is not. To attain true spiritual consciousness, it is necessary to pay attention first to the material within you that you have not yet fully used, that you are not fully using right now. Every minute of depression or anxiety, every hopeless or otherwise negative attitude towards a situation, contains various other options. But it requires an act of inner will on your part to waken forces in you that are now dormant and to make them available. Then, when the already available potentialities are being used, a much greater power of spiritual consciousness unfolds as an organic expression, gradually.

Often people go through various spiritual practices and wait for a miraculous manifestation of the greater consciousness, while their immediate mind and thought power is ensnared in the same grooves of negative attitudes, feeling, thinking, and outlook. They must either be disappointed, or they experience delusions. No exercises or efforts, no hope for grace as an intervention from outside, can bring you genuine awareness of your spiritual self and genuine manifestations of it.

The creative energy that is inherent in thoughts and thought processes is totally underestimated by most human beings. Hence, the possibilities for creating and recreating life are neglected. Making use of this creative power is a challenging and fascinating undertaking. You can explore the recesses of your conscious mind, as of this moment, to search for new, better, more creative ways of meeting difficulties; for more realistic, constructive options of reacting. You do not have to react the way you do. You have at your disposal many choices and possibilities of thinking, of directing your thoughts, your thought processes, and attitude patterns towards a new goal. To whatever degree proper self-identification has not taken place, to whatever degree in one or the other area in yourself you are still secretly identified with that which you hate most in you and

therefore resist to observe in you, to that degree your consciousness is unable to avail itself of its options and possibilities.

When you begin to pose the question to yourself, "What attitude do I choose toward what I now observe in me and what I do not like?" you have made one of the most significant discoveries in this present phase of your evolution. This does not need a subliminal breakthrough of the profounder spiritual self. It simply means using what you already have made available in the course of centuries and millennia of evolution.

What are, for instance, such choices in the face of observing dire, destructive attitudes and intents in you? You can either choose (which you have done until now, only without awareness of it) to be totally dismayed and hopeless about it. You can choose to think that it is impossible to ever be different and that this is all there is to you. Or you can choose to think that you have the power to make an immediate and drastic change. Such an attitude is no more positive than the previous one simply because it is based on unreality. It must therefore lead to inevitable disappointment and to an apparently even more justified negativity. Unrealistic hopelessness and unrealistic magical hope are the two poles of the pendulum, leading to a vicious circle. But do you not have other options available? Is it not possible to choose, with your mind as it is now, other modalities? You can say, for example, "It is likely and predictable that I will forget and become involved again in the old blindness and its conditioned reflexes. But this need not deter me. I will have to struggle again and grope to find, over and over again, my key. But I will do this, I can do this and can thereby gradually build new strength, resources, and energies. I will not be deterred by the fact that the building of a beautiful edifice needs patience. I will not be childish enough to expect this to be done at once. I want it and will use all my powers to do it, but I will be patient and realistic. I would like the spiritual powers in me to guide me, but if I cannot perceive the guidance yet because at the beginning of this undertaking my energies are too dense and my consciousness too dulled, I will trust and wait and persevere. I want to give my very best to the venture of living. I will try over and over again to face, to observe, to name, to identify what I do not like without being identified with it. I will grope for new ways of understanding it all so that I will eventually grow out of it." Such an attitude is at your disposal. It is not magic. It is an immediately available choice. You can leave from here tonight with the attitude that you would like to observe and name, rather than be submerged in, what you hitherto did not wish to name and observe. These, and other attitudes and options exist in every possible dilemma and difficulty.

Knowledge exists in you which you can bring to bear upon what you observe. If you use this available knowledge and these attitudes, you expand that knowledge and the scope of attitudes and feelings. The more you do this, the more you can be sure that the infinitely greater, unlimited consciousness of the as yet submerged spiritual self will integrate itself into your conscious mind so that you will be it. As I said previously, this happens best in a threefold dialogue: the dialogue of the conscious self with the demonic aspects, the dialogue of the conscious mind with the divine self, and the dialogue between the divine self and the demonic self. In all these three possibilities, both sides speak and listen alternately, as in every meaningful conversation. But this threefold dialogue comes only at a later stage of the development. Therefore the more you can thus perceive and observe, the easier it will become to make the next leap, and that will be the realization of your true spiritual identity. You will then truly know that this incredible, beautiful, limitless consciousness is the real you, where all the power lies and where there is nothing to fear.

My friends, once again, this lecture requires working through diligently. Much of the material cannot be taken in at first because it is difficult. It requires not only that you concentrate your mind and use your good will but also that you contact by meditation the realms of the spiritual reality and power to help you absorb and put to use what I said.

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